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Official Records

President: Mr. Kőrösi (Hungary)

The meeting was called to order at 10.05 a.m.

Agenda item 121 (continued)

The United Nations Global Counter-Terrorism Strategy

Reports of the Secretary-General (A/77/266 and A/77/718)

Draft resolution (A/77/L.78)

The President: I would like to inform members that, as mentioned in the letter from the President of the General Assembly dated 21 June, we will first take action on the draft resolution, followed by the debate on the agenda item.

Statement by the President

The President: It is with a heavy heart that I open our meeting this morning. Let me extend my sincere condolences to all who have lost their loved ones in the horrific attack that took place in Uganda on Saturday, and by expressing my sympathy to the many families living the unimaginable, still kept in the dark about the fate of their children — killed or kidnapped. Let me be clear. Targeting innocent children in the sanctuary of their school is a most heinous and insidious act. It shows the true intention of terrorism. And it is a war crime. Terrorism is a destructive wildfire, fuelled by hatred. It knows no borders and it takes thousands of innocent lives every year, stopping at no one: school children, infants, pregnant women, fathers and grandmothers. Anyone can become a victim.

Whether domestic or transnational, terrorism should have no place in today's world. Terrorism, domestic or transnational, thrives off conflict and instability, marginalization, inequalities, discrimination, human rights violations, lawlessness and poor governance. Our unsustainable way of living will only increase that pressure in the future. We have to look forward to many more crisis situations across the globe.

We must ask ourselves, should we continue to bicker over what constitutes terrorism or violent extremism, to languish in details and remain blind to the bigger picture? Or should we come together and channel all our resources to fight terrorism in all its forms? Which proactive, agile and innovative steps can we take, both online and offline? How can we make our multilateral response comprehensive, inclusive and effective? How can we collaborate on solutions that strengthen respect for human rights?

The Global Counter-Terrorism Strategy is a unique instrument that carries truly transformative potential. It provides the framework for action. It outlines the tools at our disposal. What is needed now is the political and moral will to act together. I would like to truly thank the co-facilitators of the eighth review of the Global Counter-Terrorism Strategy, Ambassador Robert Rae of Canada and Ambassador Tarek Ladeb of Tunisia. They have worked tirelessly to bring together all Member States and other stakeholders to forge consensus on our joint way forward, and they have done this despite many challenges, as we know. They have worked to find the common ground to achieve our shared goal — a world without indiscriminate violence. I invite everyone to

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join that consensus, to focus on what unites us and to think of the countless victims and the many scarred survivors of terrorism and of those across the globe who look to this House for hope and action.

Let me emphasize my strong hope that our 8 billion shareholders can see the purpose of the work we are doing here together. It is my wish that people understand and acknowledge the merit of the debates we are conducting. It is also my wish that they have a good reason to recognize the progress Member States achieved, having spent months of intense work to reduce the danger of terrorism in this fragile world. Let us remember that people outside Turtle Bay may not be interested in some sophisticated references in long resolutions we may produce. They simply want us to act together to reduce the danger of terrorism. Our joint message to them, to the world and to the perpetrators must be that the United Nations stands together in the face of terrorism and that it has been able to take a step ahead. Terrorism is not only a war on people, but a war on our minds. Let us not succumb to the division it wields. Let us rise above it.

We shall now proceed to consider draft resolution A/77/L.78. In order to ensure the smooth conduct of our proceedings today, delegations wishing to make a statement in explanation of position are kindly encouraged to do so in their statement to be delivered in the debate.

Before giving the floor for explanations of position before adoption, may I remind delegations that explanations of position are limited to 10 minutes and should be made by delegations from their seats.

I give the floor to the representative of India.

Mr. Parihar (India): Today Member States are well aware that terrorism is an existential threat to international peace and security. It knows no border, nationality or race and is a challenge that the international community must combat collectively. India has been at the forefront of the global fight against terrorism. As a country that has itself been a victim of State-sponsored cross-border terrorism for nearly three decades, India is acutely aware of the social, economic and human cost of terrorism.

My Minister for External Affairs, Mr. Subrahmanyam Jaishankar, put an eight-point action plan for the global fight against terrorism before the Member States during his statement on 12 January 2021 (see

S/2021/48, annex 5) at the ministerial meeting on the twentieth anniversary of Security Council resolution 1373 (2001) and the establishment of the Counter-Terrorism Committee. As the Chair of the Counter-Terrorism Committee last year, India strove to bring two principles into the counter-terrorism architecture of the United Nations and into the debate on terrorism at the United Nations. India hosted a special meeting of the Counter-Terrorism Committee in Mumbai and Delhi in October 2022. The Delhi Declaration that was adopted then is a landmark document to deal with the issue of countering the use of new and emerging technologies for terrorist purposes, an issue that is often of acute importance for several Member States.

In that context, my delegation has serious concerns with respect to the fourth revision of draft resolution A/77/L.78, which was circulated by the co-facilitators under silence on 19 June. We had submitted to the co-facilitators that deleting a factual reference to the Delhi Declaration, which was unanimously adopted by all Council members, was uncalled for on two principled grounds. The first is on the grounds of process. No consultation with Member States was convened and the reference to an unanimously approved Council document was removed in an opaque and non-consultative manner by the co-facilitators. The membership has not been made aware of the substantive grounds on which the reference to the Delhi Declaration was removed. That is uncalled for.

Secondly, the proceedings of the United Nations High-Level Conference of Heads of Counter-Terrorism Agencies of Member States a few days ago amply demonstrated wide support for the Delhi Declaration, which provides important policy pointers on the critical challenges facing the counter-terrorism discourse today. The Office of Counter-Terrorism, the Counter-Terrorism Committee Executive Directorate and other competent entities cited it as an example of the pathway ahead. For us now to arbitrarily ignore the same and pick and choose certain Council documents while ignoring others is equally disturbing.

In view of our concerns, as outlined today, my delegation is constrained to disassociate itself from the draft resolution on the eighth review of the Global Counter-Terrorism Strategy, which has been submitted for adoption at this meeting today.

The President: We have heard the only speaker in explanation of position before adoption.

The Assembly will now take a decision on draft resolution A/77/L.78, entitled “The United Nations Global Counter-Terrorism Strategy: eighth review”.

May I take it that the Assembly decides to adopt draft resolution A/77/L.78?

Draft resolution A/77/L.78 was adopted
(resolution 77/298).

The President: I would like to express my sincere appreciation to His Excellency Mr. Robert Rae, Permanent Representative of Canada to the United Nations, and to His Excellency Mr. Tarek Ladeb, Permanent Representative of Tunisia to the United Nations, the co-facilitators of the informal consultations, who demonstrated great ability and patience in guiding the discussions and complex negotiations on resolution 77/298.

Before giving the floor for explanations of position after the adoption, may I remind delegations that explanations of position are limited to 10 minutes and should be made by delegations from their seats.

Mr. Peñalver Portal (Cuba) (*spoke in Spanish*): For more than 60 years, the Cuban people have been the victim of innumerable terrorist actions that, for the most part, have been planned and organized from the territory of the United States of America, with the support, protection and financing of successive Governments of that country. Because of those acts, Cuba has paid a high cost in human lives and economic losses, with incalculable suffering and damage caused to the families, those affected and Cuban society in general. Due to such actions, 3,478 people have died and another 2,099 have been incapacitated.

Cuba's conduct in the fight against terrorism is irreproachable. It has never participated in the organization, financing or execution of terrorist acts against any country, nor has its territory been used or ever will be used for that purpose. It has never supported and will never support acts of international terrorism. Our country is among the 19 international conventions related to terrorism and has implemented measures to deal with that scourge. Cuba complies with and will continue to honour the commitments it has assumed in this matter. The commitment of our country in the fight against terrorism was elevated to constitutional status in 2019.

We strongly condemn all terrorist acts, methods and practices in all their forms and manifestations by whomever, against whomever and wherever they are

perpetrated, whatever their motivations, including those in which States are directly or indirectly involved. We condemn the unilateral measures and acts of certain Governments, such as the United States, which claims the right to make lists of countries as a means of political coercion. Such actions undermine the central authority of the General Assembly in the fight against terrorism and hinder international cooperation in the matter. We strongly reject the inclusion of Cuba on the list of the United States Department of State of countries that allegedly sponsor international terrorism. That designation is slanderous, hypocritical and opportunistic. It is known that these are baseless designations without authority or international support, and that they are intended to defame and coerce sovereign countries. We urge the United States Government to revoke those absurd and unjustified qualifications, which are the subject of widespread international rejection. The United Nations should speak out against such unilateral, politically manipulated lists and certifications, which are contrary to international law. Terrorism cannot be eradicated if double standards, manipulation, political opportunism and selectivity prevail when dealing with it. It is unacceptable that some terrorist acts are condemned while others are silenced, tolerated, encouraged, justified or manipulated for political and economic interests.

Our delegation remains concerned about the improper use of information and communication technologies to commit, incite, recruit, finance or plan terrorist acts, in violation of the Charter of the United Nations and international law. Terrorism cannot be linked to any religion, nationality, civilization or ethnic group. Its confrontation must be comprehensive with direct actions that include prevention to eradicate its root causes. We reaffirm the value of the United Nations Global Counter-Terrorism Strategy and the primary responsibility of States to apply it in a transparent and balanced manner across its four pillars. We actively participated in the seventh review process of the Strategy in order to achieve a balanced text that would address the demands and concerns of all. We reiterate our commitment to the adoption of a comprehensive convention on international terrorism, which includes State terrorism, and overcomes the existing legal gaps and regulatory differences. We urge that negotiations leading to that end be resumed without delay.

Finally, we highlight our firm position against terrorism, which we have expressed in international, regional and consultative organizations of which Cuba is a member State and actively participates, including the Movement of Non-Aligned Countries; the Community of Latin American and Caribbean States; the Bolivarian Alliance for the Peoples of Our America — Peoples' Trade Agreement; the Association of Caribbean States; and the Group of 77 and China. Cuba maintains a firm commitment to the Proclamation of Latin America and the Caribbean as a Zone of Peace, adopted at the second Summit of the Community of Latin American and Caribbean States, held in Havana on 28 and 29 January 2014.

Mr. Shamenov (Kyrgyzstan) (*spoke in Russian*): Allow me to express my gratitude to the United Nations for its implementation of the Global Counter-Terrorism Strategy. We thank the Permanent Representatives of Tunisia and Canada for preparing the documents related to the eighth review of the Strategy. We are also grateful for their efforts in achieving consensus on the review of the Strategy and its approval by the General Assembly.

Kyrgyzstan has fully supported the work of the States Members of the United Nations regarding the effective implementation of the Strategy. Today terrorism is one of the most serious threats to peace, to stability, to security and to the social and economic development of every State. Combating terrorism is one of Kyrgyzstan's priorities with respect to ensuring national security. We continue to take the necessary measures at the national level to effectively combat international terrorism. At the same time, Kyrgyzstan strongly supports the effective implementation of the United Nations Global Counter-Terrorism Strategy, which is a unique global document aimed at bolstering national, regional and international efforts to combat terrorism. At the same time, we note the need to take practical steps, in particular to bolster the capacity of Member States to combat terrorist threats.

Kyrgyzstan is actively participating in support of the measures being taken by the international community to combat international terrorism and extremism. In particular, we work closely with the counter-terrorism bodies of the United Nations, Commonwealth of Independent States, the Shanghai Cooperation Organization, the Collective Security Treaty Organization, the Organization for Security and Cooperation in Europe and the European Union.

We also take active part in the work of the Eurasian Group on Combating Money Laundering and Financing of Terrorism. We are convinced that the fight against this threat must be carried out under the auspices of the United Nations. Kyrgyzstan believes that any measure taken to counter this threat must be in line with all obligations under international law, including international humanitarian law and human rights law. Here, Kyrgyzstan has strictly adhered to Security Council resolutions and is focused on maintaining its close relations with the Security Council Committee established pursuant to resolution 1373 (2001) concerning counter-terrorism.

We stress that one of the most practical steps towards establishing new partnerships for international cooperation in the combat against terrorism is the work of the United Nations High-level Conference of Heads of Counter-Terrorism Agencies of Member States, which is nearing its completion. We are convinced that the successful completion of the Conference will allow for a broadened scope of practical cooperation among States Members to combat terrorism.

One of the main priorities in combating terrorism is to take preventive steps. That is why Kyrgyzstan has joined other States of Central Asia in actively working to return their citizens from combat zones. As representatives are well aware, on 7 March 2022, on the initiative of the Kyrgyz Republic and in accordance with paragraphs 2 and 4 of Security Council resolution 2610 (2021), the terrorist organization Jama'at al-Tawhid wal-Jihad was designated an international terrorist organization associated with Al-Qaida, participating in the financing, planning, preparing, facilitating and carrying out of terrorist activities. Moreover, in March 2021, the Government of Kyrgyzstan, along with United Nations agencies, carried out the humanitarian mission known as Meerim, in which 79 children, citizens of Kyrgyzstan, were repatriated from Iraq. There are many targeted actions in the plan to assist those children, including reintegration, early rehabilitation and return to safe and peaceful lives. In addition, in February Kyrgyzstan, along with partners, also carried out a mission known as Aikol, in which 59 Kyrgyz citizens were returned to the Kyrgyz Republic from Syria.

Terrorism continues to pose a major direct threat to many regions and countries. Deterring, disrupting and foiling terrorist attacks and bringing the suspected terrorist offenders to justice must remain at the heart of our work. This is in line with international law,

international legal instruments to combat terrorism, relevant Security Council resolutions and the United Nations Global Counter-Terrorism Strategy. For its part, Kyrgyzstan is ready to work more closely, both bilaterally and within regional and international organizations, which will allow us in the future to achieve concrete essential objectives to promote the development and prosperity of our countries.

Mr. Al-Hajri (Qatar) (*spoke in Arabic*): We welcome the adoption by the General Assembly of resolution 77/298, on the eighth review of the United Nations Global Counter-Terrorism Strategy. We thank the Permanent Representatives of Tunisia and Canada for leading the consultations on the resolution to achieve its adoption by consensus, demonstrates the resolve of all Member States to work together against the scourge of terrorism, which is a threat to all of us. We hope that the resolution will make it possible to strengthen the effective implementation of the Global Strategy as a framework to identify our shared goals and to guide our national and international efforts in that regard. We also thank the Secretary-General for his report on this item on the agenda (A/77/718) and commend the United Nations system for its efforts in the different areas of implementation of the Global Strategy.

The State of Qatar is fully committed to the holistic and balanced implementation of the Global Counter-Terrorism Strategy, including all four of its pillars, the relevant Security Council resolutions and the national and international conventions to which we are party. We are committed to continuing to take all the necessary steps to fight terrorism and the violent extremism that leads to terrorism. At the national level, my country continues to develop its legislation and national systems to address terrorism, the financing of terrorism and money-laundering, and to promote the capacity and coordination of relevant national bodies. We continue to develop our national counter-terrorism committee. Last year, we adopted a comprehensive national strategy on counter-terrorism that covers prevention, security, tracing and recovery, in line with the United Nations Global Counter-Terrorism Strategy. In addition, we have adopted comprehensive national policies that contribute to the prevention of terrorism.

The State of Qatar is fully aware of the pivotal role played by the United Nations in counter-terrorism. That is why we are determined to have an effective partnership with the United Nations across those various fields. My country is the largest donor to the

United Nations Office of Counter-Terrorism (UNOCT), with an annual donation of \$15 million. That donation has been renewed in advance until 2026, which will allow the Office to fulfil its mandate, including in the field of policy coordination and administrative support for the United Nations Global Counter-Terrorism Coordination Compact. We also support efforts to assess the implementation of the Global Counter-Terrorism Strategy and organize successful international and regional conferences. The Qatari donation also contributes towards financing many important strategic programmes, projects and initiatives of the UNOCT in the area of capacity-building, which has led to tangible achievements, including programmes to address the movement of terrorists and threats of terrorism against vulnerable targets, remote autonomous systems, integrated cells and counter-terrorism investigations; strengthen security for major sporting events and promote sports as a means to prevent violent extremism; and support for the victims of terrorism.

We commend the field presence of UNOCT in many countries to ensure the effective implementation of its programmes. Doha also hosts the offices of the International Hub on Behavioural Insights to Counter Terrorism, which exchanges relevant expertise and supports research, and of the Parliamentary Engagement hub, which facilitates legislative models to promote the role of parliaments in a number of related areas, including the rights of terrorist victims. We welcome the reference in the resolution adopted today to those two offices.

The nature of the terrorist threat requires coordinated and collective work. We must also respond to constantly evolving threats posed by global terrorism and modern techniques. In that regard, we note the importance of behavioural science as a way of better understanding the motives and factors that lead to extremism and terrorism. It contributes to building the flexibility of individuals and societies and is used by many governmental and academic institutions in developing evidence-based responses. We reiterate that if we are to achieve success in preventing and addressing terrorism and extremism, we must respect human rights, the rule of law and the principle of non-selectivity.

We should neither link terrorism and extremism to any country, race, religion, culture or nationality, nor equate terrorism and the legitimate right of people to fight against occupation. We stress the need to address

terrorism alongside racism, xenophobia and all forms of intolerance. We also emphasize our rejection of all hate speech, which can increase feelings of hostility and violence and lead to the proliferation of extremism and terrorism. In that regard, the State of Qatar stresses the need to address Islamophobia. We express our deep concern and condemnation of all incidents in a number of countries where the Holy Quran has been burned recently. The periodic review of the Global Counter-Terrorism Strategy should pay particular attention to those important issues in a balanced way in order to effectively fight all threats that lead to terrorism.

In conclusion, the State of Qatar takes this opportunity to condemn all terrorist acts. They are criminal acts that have no justification regardless of the motives behind them, their perpetrators, place and time of perpetration. They pose a serious threat to peace and security, human rights and the rule of law. We reiterate that the State of Qatar is committed to fighting that threat with all appropriate means.

Mr. Alzaabi (United Arab Emirates) (*spoke in Arabic*): I would like to begin by welcoming the consensus adoption of resolution 77/298, “The United Nations Global Counter-Terrorism Strategy: eighth review”. I thank the co-facilitators, the Permanent Representatives of Canada and Tunisia, for their tireless efforts during the negotiations. The United Arab Emirates also aligns itself with the statement to be delivered by the representative of the sisterly Kingdom of Saudi Arabia on behalf of the Organization of Islamic Cooperation.

Everyone is aware that terrorism is a complex global phenomenon that transcends borders, cultures and religions. Counter-terrorism requires a multidimensional and multilateral approach capable of responding to and proactively addressing the advanced methods of terrorist groups. The biannual review of the Strategy is therefore extremely important by offering us an opportunity to take stock of progress in implementing and updating the Strategy in a manner that corresponds to existing and emerging terrorist threats.

Recent years have highlighted the magnitude of challenges related to counter-terrorism. Terrorists have access to modern technology, information and communications technologies and use them to recruit, finance and launch attacks that are more complex, fatal and grave. In that regard, I refer to the use by terrorist groups of drones, virtual space, cryptocurrencies and

3D printing. In addition, they are using information technology, social networks and digital gaming platforms to spread their destructive ideas. The result is a very serious proliferation of hate speech, extremism and misleading and false information that destroy the social fabric and increase the targeting of religious and racial minorities.

Accordingly, I would like to stress two important issues. First, we must not underestimate the capacity of modern technology to threaten international peace and security if it falls into the hands of terrorist groups. Secondly, the Global Strategy must reflect that new reality and address its urgent threats in a manner that allows the international community to respond effectively. Therefore, we would like to reiterate the need for the Global Strategy to sufficiently highlight some of the emerging trends in this area that cannot be neglected. There is a dire need to promote preventive approaches at the international level in order to address intolerance and extremism before those scourges develop into terrorist acts and armed conflicts. That would save the lives of many innocent people and promote community resilience. We believe that focusing on tolerance, peaceful coexistence and dialogue is a way to build prosperous and peaceful societies that celebrate their cultural, racial and religious diversity. The United Arab Emirates has made that issue our priority at the local, regional and international levels, including through our efforts within the Organization.

We note that this month the Security Council adopted by consensus resolution 2686 (2023), on tolerance and international peace and security. The resolution was introduced by my country, in cooperation with the United Kingdom. It acknowledges that hate speech, racism and extremism are factors that lead to increased threats and recurring exacerbated conflicts. It is also the first resolution that urges countries and regional and international organizations to renounce hate speech and extremism, and calls on the United Nations entities to adopt a comprehensive response to monitor hate speech and extremism while reporting and addressing them accordingly, as well as ensuring the protection and promotion of human rights.

The commitment of the United Arab Emirates to the promotion of tolerance and peaceful coexistence was not born overnight. In fact, it is part and parcel of our State-building and preparations for the future. Therefore, we have made use of all tools, institutions and initiatives that focus on saving communities

from the scourge of extremism and terrorism, while promoting tolerance at all national and international levels. Those efforts include the establishment of the Hedayah Global Center for Excellence in Countering Violent Extremism, which plays a lead role in developing innovative solutions and establishing practical counter-terrorism strategies on global counter-terrorism, in line with the General Assembly's call for the involvement of all society in addressing terrorism. The United Arab Emirates involves all active actors, civil society, women, young people, religious leaders and others in preventing terrorism and extremism within society.

We must remain vigilant against the growing threats of terrorism, including by continuing to build on the momentum borne of the United Nations Global Counter-Terrorism Strategy and the high-level Counter-Terrorism Week. Through coordinated international efforts, we will be able to eliminate the roots of terrorism and extremism and build a better future where our people enjoy stability and prosperity.

Mr. Fouad (Egypt) (*spoke in Arabic*): Allow me to begin by congratulating you, Mr. President, and all member States on the consensus adoption of resolution 77/298, "The United Nations Global Counter-Terrorism Strategy: eighth review". My country's delegation would like to express its appreciation to the Permanent Representatives of Tunisia and Canada and their teams for the tireless efforts made in recent weeks to reach consensus.

Egypt aligns itself with the statement to be delivered by the Permanent Representative of the Kingdom of Saudi Arabia on behalf of the Organization of Islamic Cooperation. We would like to add the following remarks in our national capacity.

First, Egypt expresses its regret over the failure to develop the language of resolution 77/298 due to the lack of flexibility of some delegations and their rejection of updates that were necessary to increase the effectiveness of the Strategy, ensure its compatibility with contemporary realities and address terrorist threats.

Secondly, Egypt strongly condemns incidents of the burning of the Holy Quran by some extremist right-wing groups in certain countries. We reiterate that such hateful incidents incite terrorist acts against Muslims in those countries and spread hate speech and Islamophobia. Such incidents must be criminalized and should not be minimized. We also stress in that context that it is incomprehensible that such hostilities

are justified under the pretext of freedom of expression or other unconvincing justifications. It is regrettable that during the negotiations some delegations insisted on ignoring that concerning challenge, despite the significant flexibility demonstrated by the Islamic group in the negotiations, leading to the resolution's failure to condemn and address such heinous acts.

Thirdly, in relation to the aforementioned, my country's delegation also regrets the inability of the latest review to address terrorist attacks on the basis of xenophobia, racism and other forms of intolerance that are referred to in the report of the Secretary-General (A/77/266) as growing challenges. It is also regrettable that we were unable to reach consensus on reference to the International Day to Combat Islamophobia, which was proclaimed in the consensual resolution 76/254. The fact that Muslims are victims of hate speech and terrorism was also ignored.

Fourthly, since the adoption of the Strategy in 2006, consensus has been our approach in adopting the successive reviews. That consensus is highly appreciated and valued by Egypt. It represents unity within the international community with respect to terrorist threats. However, in recent years it has been concerning to see a growing tendency among certain delegations to impose certain issues that are irrelevant to the Strategy and its agreed four pillars. That results in weakening the collective message that we seek to deliver, negatively affects the negotiating environment and threatens the principle of consensus over the Strategy that we have all protected for 20 years. In that context, Egypt calls on all delegations to focus on the proven contemporary challenges of terrorism and on preventing distraction and an imbalance in the Strategy's four pillars.

Egypt is pursuing its efforts at the national, regional and international levels to counter terrorism and extremism through our comprehensive approach based on building the capacities of our national institutions to counter terrorism as a prerequisite for the success of any counter-terrorism effort. We do not believe those efforts to represent a militarization or securitization of counter-terrorism, as some claim. In addition, we must address the root causes of terrorism and the socioeconomic factors leading to extremism. Moreover, we monitor, analyse and refute extremist narratives through the Al-Azhar Observatory for Combating Extremism and the Salam Center for Extremism Studies, which is affiliated with the Egyptian Dar Al-Iftaa organization.

Egypt has also continued in recent years to issue an annual report on the efforts of Government agencies to counter terrorism and extremism. The language of the most recent report was developed to align with the four pillars of the Global Strategy.

At the regional level, Egypt is active in building the counter-terrorism capacities of several sisterly African States through the Egyptian Agency of Partnership for Development, as well as the Cairo International Centre for Conflict Resolution, Peacekeeping and Peacebuilding. We also support international efforts to counter terrorism through our co-chairing with the European Union of the Global Counterterrorism Forum and our active membership in the Global Coalition to Counter ISIS.

In conclusion, Egypt calls on all delegations to reflect on the lessons learned from the last and previous reviews of the Strategy in order to prepare for the next review, which we hope will lead once again to reaching consensus and which we hope will sufficiently address the priority issues related to the promotion of international cooperation on counter-terrorism.

Mr. Mahmudzoda (Tajikistan): First of all, I would like to thank Canada and Tunisia for facilitating and coordinating the negotiating process of resolution 77/298, “The United Nations Global Counter-Terrorism Strategy: eighth review”, and thank all Member States for its adoption.

The world is going through turbulent times. Such challenges as terrorism, extremism, radicalization, illicit drug trafficking and other transnational organized crime continue to seriously threaten our countries. Today terrorist groups have become increasingly innovative and proficient in adapting to changing circumstances.

Due to its geographical location, Central Asia, and in particular Tajikistan, remains at the forefront of countering the aforementioned modern threats and challenges. Central Asia adopted its Joint Plan of Action in 2011, the first regional framework designed to address the threat of terrorism through a common approach, based on the United Nations Global Counter-Terrorism Strategy and strengthened international partnership. Phase IV of the Joint Plan of Action project 2022–2025 was successfully launched during the annual meeting of Deputy Ministers for Foreign Affairs of Central Asia, held on 8 December 2021 in Dushanbe. Furthermore, to promote the implementation of the United Nations

Global Counter-Terrorism Strategy and relevant Security Council resolutions at the national level, the Government of Tajikistan successfully implemented its National Strategy on Combating Terrorism and Extremism for 2016–2020 and is realizing the second phase of its Strategy on Countering Extremism and Terrorism for the period 2021–2025.

To advance the capacity of law enforcement and other agencies to combat terrorism, prevent violent extremism, enhance border security and prevent terrorist financing, Tajikistan continues to take the following additional steps and efficient and effective measures. In order to prevent the spread of extremist ideas in correctional institutions, the methodological and preventive capacity of the educational units of those institutions has been strengthened and enhanced. Laws on countering extremism and combating terrorism were adopted in 2020 and 2021, defining the rights and obligations of State authorities in that field, as well as forms and liability for extremist actions and measures to prevent extremist activities. The Decree of the President of Tajikistan on the National Concept of Countering the Laundering of the Proceeds of Crime, the Financing of Terrorism and the Financing of the Proliferation of Weapons of Mass Destruction for 2018–2025 was adopted in 2018.

A number of revisions and amendments have been made to criminal and administrative legislation with a view to criminalizing new acts and increasing — and at some points, decreasing — liability for crimes and offences of an extremist and terrorist nature. In the process of strengthening the institutional framework for countering extremism and terrorism, the Department for Combating Extremism and Terrorism and the Unified Fusion Centre for Preventing Extremism, Terrorism and Cybercrimes have been established in the General Prosecutor’s Office. An inter-agency task force has been set up to coordinate the activities of operational services and investigative units, as well as to identify and investigate crimes involving the recruitment of citizens to terrorist organizations. Regular operational measures are being taken to suppress acts of terrorism in preparation and to identify persons involved in extremist and terrorist activities in the territory of Tajikistan.

As part of the implementation of the National Strategy of the Republic of Tajikistan on Countering Terrorism and Extremism for 2016–2020, the Government of the country, among other significant achievements, has

also improved its mechanism for preventing extremism and strengthened the role of education and civil society. The successful implementation of that document has created a favourable environment for the development and adoption of a new strategy for 2021–2025. A special secretariat has been created for the successful implementation of the strategy, and there is a platform for cooperation between public implementing institutions and international and civil society organizations.

The specific actions undertaken by the Government of Tajikistan has resulted in the return of more than 350 citizens of our country, mainly women and children, from Syria and Iraq. Currently, we are continuing effective actions to rehabilitate and reintegrate them within society. On 18 and 19 October 2022, a High-Level Conference on International and Regional Border Security and Management Cooperation to Counter Terrorism and Prevent the Movement of Terrorists was hosted by the Government of the Republic of Tajikistan, in cooperation with the Office of Counter-Terrorism (UNOCT) and other partners. The Dushanbe Conference was the third milestone in a series of events within the Dushanbe process, pursuant to the High-Level Conference on International and Regional Cooperation on Countering Terrorism and its Financing Through Illicit Drug Trafficking and Organized Crime, held in Dushanbe on 16 and 17 May 2019. The High-level International Conference on Countering Terrorism and Preventing Violent Extremism, hosted by the Government of the Republic of Tajikistan in cooperation with the United Nations and other international partners, was held in Dushanbe on 3 and 4 May 2018.

Last but not least, my delegation acknowledges with appreciation the partnership and cooperation of the United Nations Office of Counter-Terrorism and thanks UNOCT and many other counterparts from the international community for providing coordination and coherence in the implementation of activities to prevent and counter violent extremism, including the development and implementation of the National Strategy and Action Plan of the Republic of Tajikistan on Countering Terrorism and Extremism for 2021–2025, and for convening international conferences in Tajikistan.

Ms. Jamal (Bahrain): It is a pleasure to address the General Assembly in person for the first time since our last review took place over video conferencing during the pandemic, when I first took on my current role at

the Foreign Ministry of the Kingdom of Bahrain. So much has happened since then. There has been a great deal of positivity at the national, regional and global levels, and the return to normalcy and interaction is the cherry on top.

The last two years have brought about numerous opportunities for us to comprehend the many developments on the terrorism and extremism landscapes. The hype of events has made sure that our terminology has grown fourfold, and it has become hard to keep up nowadays. Adding to that, the incessant need to properly interpret specialized, very experience-centric terminology between languages to ensure that our longer-term knowledge, commitments and goals remain parallel, if not similar, emphasizes the role of academics and strategic communications experts in particular. Such a struggle makes it imperative that we consider our collective institutional memory, given how, over the years, expertise has been gradually spreading out into a variety of either connected or dispersed fields. Networks, once created under the pillar of the Global Coalition against Daesh, are now working in silos perhaps due to the change in objective or due to a difference in approach. That does necessarily affect the current impact on target audiences but does not ensure that a longer-term barricade can be called upon immediately to address a collective threat requiring a unified narrative.

We in the region have had our fair share of work cut out for us and have managed to build monitoring and evaluation standards that have proved suitable for our *modus operandi* at least. I remember just a few years ago when it was common to find gaps in assessment techniques used in projects strategic communications campaigns to prevent violent extremism; but today it seems there is a general satisfaction with the realities of success and the means of achieving behavioural and attitudinal change.

Those here in attendance who are familiar with our regional approaches know that across the board we prefer to use a direct counter-narrative that negates criminal extremist ideology based on religious principles and that derives support from nationalistic values that replace vulnerability with sociopsychological safeguards. Such an approach requires expert comprehension of the tenets of each specific ideology to be addressed head on as it develops, which makes a one-size-fits-all approach impossible.

As the world gradually seeks a sustainable solution for the rehabilitation and reintegration of terrorist fighters, our individual country approaches will define success. That will impact safety and security everywhere, making this United Nations congregation the most suitable place to understand that what we decide today will impact the future stability and peace of our entire world. Extremism, its definition, its prevention and its depletion should be at the heart of our debate, not simply within the context of counter terrorism but a theme, a term, an objective and an industry in itself. Within the United Nations Global Counter-Terrorism Strategy framework and the deliberations of today's United Nations agenda, Bahrain, my country, stands here today ready, committed and proud.

Mr. Frank (Switzerland) (*spoke in French*): Today concludes the eighth review of the United Nations Global Counter-Terrorism Strategy, a process centred on the establishment of a unified global response to prevent and counter terrorism. Allow me at the outset to thank the co-facilitators, Mr. Robert Rae of Canada and Mr. Tarek Ladeb of Tunisia, and their teams for having guided our work so skilfully. My delegation congratulates them on the results we have achieved.

It is critical that the fight against terrorism remain an integral part of multilateralism and that mutual trust be strengthened in order to find consensus-based solutions. As our Minister for Foreign Affairs, Mr. Ignazio Cassis, stated at the high-level event held on 3 May under the Swiss presidency of the Security Council, "Yes, the multilateral system is under stress, but no, it is not bankrupt" (*S/PV.9315, p.8*). Everything is possible where there is trust, and the consensus adoption of resolution 77/298 today is proof of that.

Allow me to raise three essential priorities for Switzerland during these negotiations.

First, we must guarantee full respect for the rule of law and international law, in particular human rights and international humanitarian law, in any effort aimed at countering violent extremism and terrorism. Moreover, we must take gender into account in terms of the impact of terrorism and the variety of roles it can play in terms of prevention. To that end, Member States and the United Nations must make progress in terms of accountability and prevention, combat impunity and implement the appropriate measures. Today's resolution is a step in the right direction, but we must go further. We must have an appropriate assessment of the impact

of United Nations counter-terrorism activities on the rule of law, international law and gender equality. An effective review mechanism would be a significant contribution in terms of learning lessons, making continuous improvements and guaranteeing respect for the commitments that we have made.

Secondly, we must ensure that the measures taken to combat terrorism, including United Nations sanctions, do not undermine humanitarian efforts. The rapid, safe and barrier-free provision of humanitarian assistance and protection, as envisaged under international humanitarian law, must be the highest priority for us all. In that regard, Switzerland calls for the comprehensive and immediate implementation of Security Council resolution 2664 (2022), in particular in the context of counter-terrorism. The implementation of the Global Counter-Terrorism Strategy must effectively take significant developments into account.

Thirdly, clear and transparent approaches based on reliable and results-oriented data must be at the foundation of any actions taken by the United Nations and its Member States. Switzerland welcomes the fact that the resolution contains provisions to that effect. It is essential to measure the effects and effectiveness of and progress in the implementation of the Global Strategy to understand the effects, to identify where we have been successful and to introduce improvements where they are needed. Ensuring that our results are developed in a collective and transparent manner that involves all stakeholders, in particular civil society, is the best way to achieve that.

Today we adopted the resolution emerging from the eighth review of the United Nations Global Counter-Terrorism Strategy; however, this does not mean that our work is complete. Rather, it continues. We must now promote the resolution and track its development. Its implementation and assessment are equal steps for a proper global strategic response to terrorism.

Mr. Alwasil (Saudi Arabia): I have the honour to speak on behalf of the States members of the Organization of Islamic Cooperation (OIC) upon the adoption of resolution 77/298, on the eighth review of the United Nations Global Counter-Terrorism Strategy (GCTS). This review always offers a useful opportunity to renew our collective and unwavering resolve to combat terrorism and promote international peace and security.

The OIC would like to congratulate you, Mr. President, as well as to congratulate and thank the co-facilitators of the eighth GCTS review, Ambassador Tarek Ladeb of Tunisia and Ambassador Robert Rae of Canada, for their valuable efforts throughout the negotiations. The OIC also highly values and appreciates the tireless efforts of Mr. Yassine Salah and Mr. Hussein Hirji, the counter-terrorism experts of the Permanent Missions of Tunisia and Canada, who have strived over the past weeks to secure consensus among delegations on this GCTS review resolution. I also wish to express a special thanks to our expert in the Permanent Mission of the Kingdom of Saudi Arabia, Mr. Khalid Felemban, for his coordination of the OIC positions.

In our view, the GCTS biannual reviews have so far been an attestation to the significant role multilateralism can still play in today's polarized world and despite all challenges. The adoption by consensus of the GCTS in 2006 (resolution 60/288) and all its reviews until the current eighth one, has contributed to sending a strong and necessary message on our united global approach to counter-terrorism and violent extremism conducive to terrorism in all its manifestations, as embodied in the Strategy, with its four pillars. Thus, cognizant of the paramount significance of consensus in that unique process, the OIC as the largest negotiating block, comprising 57 Member States, in that process, has always strived for maintaining this practice as the *modus operandi* for our consecutive reviews and has often made considerable compromises and sacrifices towards that end.

The OIC engaged in the negotiations over the past weeks in good faith and the firm belief that it was necessary to have an updated Strategy that reflects the emerging new threats and challenges that have prevailed since the last review in 2021. Throughout the negotiations, the OIC demonstrated the utmost flexibility and transparency, despite genuine reservations and concerns regarding the process and the evident lack of flexibility on the part of certain delegations. The OIC regrets that the eighth review failed to reach consensus on many proposals that reflect recent events and emerging new trends since the last review. Those include proposals tabled by the OIC to condemn the recurrent attempts and acts of racist and extremist right-wing elements to instigate violence and terrorism against Muslims through the deliberate desecration of mosques and the burning of their most sacred text, the Holy Quran. Our group spent endless

hours explaining how such acts of hatred promote Islamophobic, anti-minority and anti-immigrant narratives, and how they constitute criminal instigation of terrorism, which should be condemned in the strongest terms and penalized. Nonetheless, our group was surprised by the justifications of such acts of hatred and instigation of terrorism by some delegations.

Consistent with the OIC's long-standing approach of flexibility and negotiating in good faith, we proposed language formulations that clearly avoided all the so-called red lines expressed by the objecting delegations, based on consensus language from resolutions they themselves have submitted to the General Assembly. Unfortunately, we had no luck. That complete rejection of merely considering linguistic proposals to capture and call out those heinous acts, as mitigated as they may be, leaves us disappointed by the fact that the few objecting delegations did not make any effort to reach consensus on that important issue and rejected our continuous efforts to reach a consensual solution.

Nonetheless, it would be also fair to state on the record that our failure today to condemn such acts sends a clear message that incitement to terrorism against Muslims can be tolerated. In the same vein, the OIC is also extremely disappointed that the eighth review resolution failed to include a reference to the International Day to Combat Islamophobia, which was proclaimed based on the recent General Assembly consensus resolution 76/254. Our group rejects such failure and, despite the unwillingness of a few delegations who opposed our proposals, remains united and unequivocal in continuing its efforts to ensure a collective effort at the international level to combat such phenomena.

We would like also to recall the commitments expressed, *inter alia*, in the present resolution and previous GCTS resolutions to strengthening international cooperation to prevent and combat terrorism in all its forms and manifestations and reiterate that terrorism and incitement to terrorist and violent acts against Muslims as an increasing form and manifestation of terrorism is not an exception. We should demonstrate our resolve and unfaltering determination to combat terrorism by enhancing international cooperation to counter such heinous acts so as to prevent people from falling victim to those reprehensible attempts and acts, to suppress the normalization of such acts of violence and terrorism and, finally, to advance our common goal of a world free of terrorism. Given that the

ongoing misuse of information and communications technologies by such groups has already given rise to the broad scope and scale of such acts of violence and terrorism against Muslims, we would like to highlight the responsibility of the global Internet governance system and global social media platforms in engaging in effective cooperation with law enforcement to prevent the dissemination of hatred and acts of incitement to terrorism against Muslims.

The OIC is also very concerned about the never-ending quest by some delegations to shift the focus of the GCTS from terrorism to many other issues that are more suited to the Third Committee. Such attempts do not contribute to enhancing the capacity of Member States or international cooperation to counter terrorism. To the contrary, they create a distraction and threaten to disrupt the delicate balance achieved across the four pillars of the GCTS and will lead us sooner or later to losing the consensus nature of the GCTS review resolutions — a threat that is nearing with every review. We therefore call on all Member States to refrain from such attempts and to focus on real, meaningful and action-oriented updates that have an appreciable impact on countering terrorism worldwide.

To conclude, we would like to reaffirm that terrorism and violent extremism conducive to terrorism cannot and should not be associated with any religion, nationality, civilization or ethnic group.

Finally, the OIC welcomes the decision to convene the ninth biennial review of the Strategy in 2026, which will coincide with the twentieth anniversary of the launching of the GCTS. The OIC sincerely hopes that all Member States will be able, during the next review of the Strategy, to engage more effectively and in the spirit of consensus and compromise to realize a review document that is more reflective of the concerns and priorities of Member States, while learning from the shortfalls from previous reviews, including this current one.

Mr. Rae (Canada): On 22 June 1985, exactly 38 years ago today, a plane took off from Vancouver to Toronto with a bomb that was built in Canada by violent extremists in my country. The luggage in which that bomb was hidden made its way onto a plane that took off from Toronto, my hometown, on Air India Flight 182, which then picked up more passengers in Montreal and took off for London, after which it was intended to fly to Delhi. Given the time of the year,

just like today, students were finishing school, and many Canadians with family ties to India were going to see loved ones. Shortly after midnight on 23 June, that bomb — which had gone undetected — went off, and all 329 people on board that plane perished, with the bodies being identified by Canadian families who descended on Cork, Ireland, supported by an incredible Irish population who rallied to house them.

That same day, two baggage handlers in Narita, Japan, were killed by a bomb that also originated on a separate flight from Vancouver. That fateful day, 23 June, which Canadians will commemorate tomorrow, remained the deadliest act of aviation terrorism until the events of 9/11 and its devastating impact on this city of New York. Indeed, after 9/11 my Government asked me to examine the incident and the lessons learned from it for our then counter-terrorism posture. I will not go into the details of that report, which members can still find online under the title “Lessons to be learned”, but I mention all this because, when the President of the General Assembly asked me and my dear colleague Ambassador Ladeb of Tunisia to co-facilitate the eighth review of the United Nations Global Counter-Terrorism Strategy, I was motivated by the victims aboard that flight and so many others who have shared their stories with me, and to make a further contribution to the fight against this global scourge.

I say these words without any sense of defensiveness, as follows. Ambassador Ladeb and I are not the co-authors of the text. That is not what the co-facilitation process is all about. It is about member States agreeing with other member States that have different points of view. What we can do and what I hope we were successful in doing is shaping the process and helping to identify the consensus that actually exists among Member States. We tried to engage directly and transparently with all the parties who sought to be actively included in the process. We built on past practice and sought to further consultations with civil society, with briefings from numerous United Nations Global Counter-Terrorism Coordination Compact entities in the process, and will seek to ensure that the practice is preserved in the development of future road maps.

As one of the co-facilitators, let me thank several people and groups. I know I will be followed in this by my good friend Ambassador Ladeb as well. First of all, I would like to thank you, Mr. President, for giving us this honour, although I must confess that that was

not necessarily my feeling on every single day in the last little while. I also want to express my thanks to Under-Secretary-General Voronkov and his team, the United Nations Office of Counter-Terrorism (UNOCT) and the Counter-Terrorism Committee Executive Directorate for the assessments and analysis that have kept us all current. I thank the United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime for its strong field presence and experience and for briefing Member States on new programmes. I thank the Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Human Rights and the Special Rapporteur for reminding us to be aware of the human rights impact of all of our counter-terrorism efforts and the universality of our obligations. Of course, I want to thank my friend and colleague Ambassador Tarek Ladeb. We have become good buddies in the last little while and it has been good to work with him and his team. I thank my assistant, Hussein Hirji, who has been thanked by others. I think we all know that the process of facilitation is carried out by what we call experts who have just spent countless hours working together to help us get to this finish line.

I want to say a word about the Strategy overall. In my view, we actually made some progress in the eighth review. Listening to the speeches this morning, it is clear that we did not make all the progress that some countries, representatives and groups would have liked, and that is a reality. It is in the nature of the process. We do not carry out these discussions in a perfect world. We do not carry them out without the geopolitics of our time taking place. We carry them out in a way that is never going to be perfect; however, we try to advance a little bit, bit by bit, where we think the consensus can go and with a view to strengthening it.

I think it is fair to say that a few things have changed over the past several years in the landscape. The first one is — and perhaps my narrative about the tragic events in India, Canada and Ireland illustrates this — to appreciate that the nature of the beast is global. People move. People travel. The idea that terrorism and its threat is somehow confined to only one part of the world or to a particular set of issues is not true. It is a truly global phenomenon. While it comes out of conflict zones, those conflict zones have impacts all over the world simply because of the nature of globalization. Terrorists used to target planes to hijack or blow up; now they seek out and use drones. It therefore depends on technologies. That is one. The Internet obviously is another. The speed with which

communication takes place and the way in which it takes hold of the individual citizen and the individual young person means that an event that happens in one part of the world can have a direct impact on another part of the world because of the person who is getting the misinformation or disinformation or hate speech online. That is where the process of radicalization is taking place. Recruitment is not confined to a geographic area. The recruitment is taking place online right now as we speak. There are young people sitting in front of a screen who are watching hateful propaganda and who are being persuaded by it and attracted by it. They could live in New York, Delhi, Toronto, Buenos Aires or anywhere.

As we went through the seventh review, people initially wanted a technical rollover. Since we had made progress in the seventh review, the idea was to build on that. But as we did that, each representative would come to us and say they wanted to do a technical rollover but that there was just one new thing they would like to add that reflected their point of view. So, we listened to that, obviously, as co-facilitators, but we also said that the co-facilitators were not the ones who needed to be persuaded because for every addition someone wanted to make, there was someone else wanting to make another one. I have heard the frustration of colleagues from the podium and I understand the frustration, but the reality is that this is the process of consensus we have created, and I think the advantage of consensus is that it allows us to speak on behalf of all the citizens of the world and to say that, at a very minimum, this is where we need to go. I think that is something we would lose if we simply went paragraph by paragraph, word by word, vote by vote and started dividing up even more than we are already divided.

But, speaking personally and speaking in my national capacity, I have to say that some of the things that were suggested have tremendous merit. I think we do have to deal with new forms of hatred. I think we do have to deal with Islamophobia. But we should find it in our hearts to deal with antisemitism and any other form of racial hatred that desecrates religions and that leads to violence. We have to understand the legitimate concerns of free speech, but we also have to understand that direct incitement remains a criminal act. So, we were able to do some things. We reflected important meetings that have been held in Spain, India and Tajikistan, as well as the United Nations Global Congress of Victims of Terrorism in New York.

Although there was no consensus on the outcome documents for those meetings — including, regrettably, the Delhi Declaration — there was a recognition that those discussions were taking place on an ongoing basis. We discussed the importance of further engaging civil society, particularly around counter-terrorism, with many emphasizing the importance of protection. And while we could not agree on specific stronger language, which I find regrettable, there is a new reference to the importance of supporting women-led civil society.

We discussed the question of oversight of the growing United Nations architecture on counter-terrorism. The philosophy we have adopted in Canada is to say that measures against terrorism and the threat of terrorism have to be robust, but that the oversight to ensure that civil liberties are protected also has to be robust. That is where I think we need to strike the balance here at the United Nations. I, for one, certainly hope that over the next three years we will be able to take away some of the fears and concerns that we heard expressed about what that would mean or how it would impact the work of the agencies.

I think we have seen leadership from the Secretary-General in his report on the growth of racist and sexist extremism (A/77/266), and I think his reports are a first step in understanding this threat. We agree that more research and data are going to be required. To achieve that, we have made an important agreement that the next cycle will take three years. As my colleague from Saudi Arabia pointed out, it will now take place at the twentieth anniversary of the whole Strategy. This is a learning exercise for all of us. It is a learning exercise for the globe. We took a dramatic step after 9/11 to recognize that global terrorism is something that can have an impact on every country around the world and that we need to create a global strategy to deal with a global phenomenon.

(spoke in French)

Terrorism and its risks are not restricted to any one country, conflict zone or region. They are not limited by ethnicity or determined by one religion or another. Those things have nothing to do with the situation. The reality of our situation in the world today is that terrorism is a threat to everyone. It is a threat to every citizen of the world. It is a threat that can have terrible impacts on the peoples of the world. That is why I believe our work is absolutely essential.

(spoke in English)

In my opening comments, I referred to the Air India bombing of 1985. Just before I completed that report, I had a visit from a man who I did not know. He came with a package for me, and I opened it in front of him. He told me that he was related to a little girl who was on the plane, and he showed me her picture. Her name was Kiranjit Rai. He said, “I want you to know that what you are doing is not about numbers or people that you do not know. So let me tell you about her”. And he did. He then showed me something that really shook me. He showed me the letters that the children in her class at a public school in Toronto had sent to her family. He also gave me the picture and he said, “I want you to keep this picture and put it on your desk”. It came in a little frame. Any who come to my residence will see that picture. It is on my desk.

Finally, as we go forward, I would ask members to think about a couple of things. The first one is the enduring value of empathy. We should find it in our hearts to speak not only about the hatred against ourselves or our own group. We should find it in our hearts to speak more about the hatred that exists for others as well. That is what empathy means. It means the ability to really understand what other people are going through. We should find it in our hearts to do that. In order to do that, we not only have to demonstrate that capacity for empathy and understanding, but we also have to really listen to what other people are saying about what we have just said. That is what this process is about. That is what the General Assembly at its best is about. It is about empathy, and it is about listening.

Finally, it is about action. We took action to create UNOCT. We took action to try to demonstrate that we were capable as a global community to coordinate all of our national efforts to deal with the impact of terrorism on our world. We have now created an architecture with the four pillars that have been so aptly described and now we have to keep on building. Let us never forget and let us keep in our mind’s eye and in our hearts the realities of all those who have been killed, all those who are at risk, and all those whose security is not sufficiently protected because our efforts have been imperfect. Can we do it better next time? I hope so. We must keep trying.

The President: On a personal note, I would like to thank Ambassador Rae of Canada and his counterpart, Ambassador Tarek Ladeb of Tunisia, for

their dedication, empathy, hard work and leadership, which helped us successfully to come around and to stand together when adopting resolution 77/298. I offer many thanks on behalf of the General Assembly.

Mr. Ladeb (Tunisia): At the outset, I would like to thank you, Mr. President, for the trust you placed in my colleague the Permanent Representative of Canada, Ambassador Bob Rae, and myself to facilitate the eighth review of the United Nations Global Counter-Terrorism Strategy.

All through this process, we have strived to accomplish this task in the best manner we could and undertook to listen carefully to and to work closely with each and every delegation. We were keen also to ensure an inclusive process and to seek the views of all stakeholders, including governmental and non-governmental organizations, representatives of civil society, experts, academia and United Nations entities.

I should say that bringing all Member States on board was not an easy task, but we tried hard up to the last minute. Here I would like to commend all delegations for their hard work, their flexibility and constructive engagement during the negotiations, which made this consensus possible and facilitated our reaching the text of resolution 77/298, which, although considered imperfect by some delegations, remains a positive outcome, as it contains a number of key messages about, first, our collective resolve to strengthen international cooperation to prevent and combat terrorism in all its forms and manifestations, including through a comprehensive approach that seeks to address its root causes while ensuring compliance with human rights, fundamental freedoms and the rule of law; secondly, our determination to ensure an integrated and balanced implementation of the strategy in all its pillars; and thirdly, our keen interest in keeping the Strategy relevant and able to adapt to the global threat landscape and emerging new trends of international terrorism, an issue which we thoroughly discussed at the high-level Conference on Tuesday.

We might have some different views on a few aspects of the resolution or about elements that unfortunately could not be included without jeopardizing consensus, but I remain convinced that what is most important today is what unites us. Despite those differences, we stand united against terrorism and violent extremism conducive to terrorism in all their forms and manifestations. Today

we share a common conviction that we need a holistic approach to address all drivers of that scourge and that we cannot respond to the threat efficiently without reinforcing national capacities or without promoting tolerance, respect for diversity, dialogue, interreligious and intercultural understanding among peoples at the national, regional and global levels.

Today we concur that we need appropriate measures to address the new and emerging terrorist threats based on xenophobia, racism and other forms of intolerance, or in the name of religion or belief. We need also to upscale our cooperation and coordination with all stakeholders to counter the increasing and evolving use by terrorists of information and communications technologies and other emerging technologies to commit, incite, recruit for, fund or plan terrorist acts.

I could go on for hours listing all the important elements contained in the document before us on which we all agree and which constitute our common road map to combat terrorism, a scourge that no country can face by itself. The United Nations Global Counter-Terrorism Strategy, which we have reviewed today, remains a key framework for our collective action, and it needs our support and our unity to remain relevant and up to date.

Finally, I would be remiss not to extend my warm thanks to Secretary-General António Guterres, the Under-Secretary General of the United Nations Office of Counter-Terrorism, Mr. Vladimir Voronkov, and all the staff of the United Nations Office of Counter-Terrorism for their efforts, assistance and facilities, which contributed to achieving the results that we have accomplished. My thanks and appreciation go to my friend Ambassador Bob Rae and his team, especially Hussein Hirji, and to my colleague Yassine Salah for their tireless efforts along the process. Countering terrorism is a priority we all share and only together can we face such a global threat.

The President: The words of gratitude expressed just a couple of minutes ago to Ambassador Bob Rae go equally go to Ambassador Tarek Ladeb on behalf of the General Assembly.

I now give the floor to the representative of the European Union, in its capacity as observer.

Mr. Skoog (European Union): I am honoured to deliver remarks on behalf of the European Union (EU) and its member States on the occasion of the eighth review of the United Nations Global Counter-Terrorism Strategy.

The candidate countries Serbia, Albania, the Republic of Moldova and Bosnia and Herzegovina; the potential candidate country Georgia; and the European Free Trade Association country Iceland, member of the European Economic Area; as well as Monaco and San Marino align themselves with this statement. In the interest of time and out of respect for other speakers coming after me, I would like to shorten my intervention. The full version is available and will be published.

Let me start by welcoming the adoption by consensus of resolution 77/298, on the eighth review of the United Nations Global Counter-Terrorism Strategy, and by thanking the co-facilitators, the Permanent Representatives of Canada and Tunisia, for their tireless efforts in advancing the process with the aim of ensuring that the Strategy is updated to reflect the threat and the challenges we face today. I wish to tell the two of them that everything I will say now should in no way reflect anything negative or anything short of the highest esteem we hold for our co-facilitators for their dedicated work.

Counter-terrorism remains at the top of the EU agenda but also at the forefront of efforts to promote peace and security. The evolving threat of terrorism and of violent extremism conducive to terrorism, in all their forms and irrespective of their origin, continues to pose a major risk to all of us. The continuous threat posed by Al-Qaida and Daesh and by their affiliates in Afghanistan and Central Asia, the Sahel and across the African continent, in Syria, Iraq and elsewhere attest to that. The threat posed by terrorist groups and lone actors and the growth of politically motivated extremism and terrorism also concern us. As to the misuse of emerging technologies for terrorist purposes and new avenues for terrorist financing, they highlight the need for enhanced multilateral engagement and strengthened cooperation in accordance with our commonly shared principles.

We must continue to work together to build upon progress achieved, while better prioritizing and coordinating our activities. We must ensure that our efforts are in line with our common fundamental values. The eighth review gives us the opportunity to refocus our attention in that regard. The EU and its member States welcome the fact that the review takes into account some of these issues, but we also think that many challenges remain. Despite several months of inclusive consultations led by the co-facilitators in a perfect way, the text we adopted today is close to a technical rollover. Our sincere hope is that the next

review will see the implementation of an ambitious consensus that corresponds to the challenges we all face. It is also necessary to ensure that actions to address the threat of terrorism and violent extremism are real. That requires actions that respect human rights and fundamental freedoms and that are not used against civil society. It is therefore all the more important that we continue to implement the Strategy following the direction that we set out in the previous review and confirmed in this one. We must strengthen in particular actions under the fourth pillar, which concerns human rights and the rule of law.

In the face of terrorist attacks, the European Union and our member States uphold the common values that underpin our pluralist societies and continue to pursue efforts to defend them with determination. Counter-terrorism actions must always respect international law, in particular international human rights law, international refugee law and international humanitarian law. What is more, counter-terrorism measures must not be misused to suppress perceived dissent and silence human rights defenders. That includes instances of reprisal for engagement with the United Nations.

Civil society and human rights defenders play an essential role in guiding States in their fight against terrorism and violent extremism. In the face of a continued shrinking of the civic space, we should continue our efforts to ensure better protection for civil society representatives and human rights defenders, as well as continue to pay due attention to the gender dimension. We look to the leadership of Under-Secretary-General Voronkov and the United Nations Office of Counter-Terrorism, the Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Human Rights, UN-Women and other Global Counter-Terrorism Coordination Compact entities.

The EU and its member States fully support a whole-of-society approach to implementing the Global Counter-Terrorism Strategy, and we call for strengthened collaboration and cooperation between Governments and civil society. In addition, we cannot insist enough on the importance of the full, equal and meaningful participation and leadership of women in efforts to prevent and counter terrorism and violent extremism. We therefore welcome the new reference to women-led civil society organizations in the Strategy.

We must also protect the humanitarian space. Countering terrorism and providing humanitarian assistance are mutually inclusive objectives. We welcome the inclusion of a reference to Security Council resolution 2664 (2022) in the Strategy. At the same time, we regret that it proved impossible to highlight even further the significance of that resolution. What is more, we must step up our efforts to isolate terrorists by drying up all their sources of financing. That requires oversight mechanisms that follow the recommendations of the Financial Action Task Force and addressing developments such as cryptocurrencies. We regret that those elements have not been included in the resolution.

We must tackle the misuse of information and communication technologies through a multi-stakeholder approach, including by working with civil society and in close cooperation with the private sector, while providing alternative narratives. More work is needed to strengthen dialogue with information and communications technologies companies and to conduct research on the role of algorithms in the spreading of terrorist material online.

Let me turn to the institutional perspective. Building on the seventh review and in the light of the establishment of the Human Rights and Gender Section in the United Nations Office of Counter-Terrorism, we encourage the United Nations Office of Counter-Terrorism and all Global Compact entities to continue their efforts for the better mainstreaming of human rights and gender as cross-cutting issues, as well as for all counter-terrorism activities. Although we regret that consensus escaped delegations with regard to a more ambitious language in the Strategy, we recognize the significance of exchanges of views during the review process. We look forward to sustained progress and continued reporting on those efforts.

We also wish to insist that it is crucial that the United Nations Office of Counter-Terrorism and the Global Compact enhance their coordination and coherence in the field through consultative inter-agency efforts. They should integrate their field-level engagement, including among resident coordinators and within United Nations country teams in order to support such broader United Nations peace and security and development agendas as the Secretary-General's reforms and his prevention agenda.

We welcome the fact that the Strategy calls for future reporting on the implementation of all four pillars and relies on a results framework. That will allow Member

States to monitor and, ultimately, assess the overall impact and comprehensive, integrated implementation of the Strategy. Monitoring and evaluation standards are a widely recognized concept for quality assurance, and we should strive to implement them in United Nations counter-terrorism efforts.

Finally, the EU and its member States remain committed to multilateralism and support global efforts to fight terrorism and violent extremism in support of the United Nations, including by devoting considerable financial resources to counter-terrorism capacity-building partnerships that underpin the implementation of the Strategy. The EU and its member States are among the prime contributors to the Global Compact.

We would also like to commend the proactive engagement of the co-facilitators with civil society in the review, and we would like to thank civil society for its constructive partnerships and cooperation throughout this process. We will continue to provide steadfast support for and to collaborate with all the Compact entities, as well as with the Special Rapporteur on the promotion and protection of human rights and fundamental freedoms while countering terrorism, with a view to achieving the full implementation of the Global Counter-Terrorism Strategy. Countering terrorism is a priority we all share. Together, we — the United Nations, the European Union and the Member States — have been tirelessly committed to mitigating that scourge. Only together can we put a stop to terrorists and their backers.

Mr. Nasution (Indonesia): Allow me to begin by extending our appreciation to the co-facilitators of the eighth review, Ambassador Tarek Ladeb of Tunisia and Ambassador Robert Rae of Canada, for their tireless efforts throughout the process.

Indonesia aligns itself with the statement delivered by the representative of Saudi Arabia on behalf of the Organization of Islamic Cooperation (OIC).

We echo the OIC's concerns that the current review has fallen short of reflecting recent events and emerging trends, particularly acts of hatred that may instigate violence and terrorism. However, despite those challenges, we welcome the consensual adoption of resolution 77/298, on the eighth review of the United Nations Global Counter-Terrorism Strategy (GCTS). We believe that the GCTS remains an important instrument to guide and enhance our combined efforts to counter terrorism. As emphasized by the Secretary-General,

while we have made some significant gains over the years, terrorism and violent extremism continue to take root and grow, so we must stand as one against that global threat. On that note, allow me to underscore several points.

The first point concerns promoting respect for diversity, tolerance and coexistence as an investment towards prevention. Indonesia is concerned over the rising tide of Islamophobia and recent incidents of the burning of the Holy Quran, the repercussions of which, if left unmanaged, may contribute to a vicious cycle of violence. Therefore, it is imperative to integrate those facts and formulate a more comprehensive approach within our strategy to effectively address conditions that could incite acts of terrorism and also further contribute towards a peaceful, just and inclusive society.

The second point concerns enhancing capacity-building and sharing best practices. With various new and emerging threats, including the use of new technologies, we need to continuously adapt and innovate. Indonesia is of the view that the Strategy provides ample opportunities for Member States to bolster international, regional and subregional cooperation in a more coordinated and coherent manner. That will also lead to better synergy and effectiveness in implementing the strategy, not only among Member States, but also within the United Nations system itself.

In the context of our region, States members of the Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN) have taken significant steps to enhance regional cooperation in countering terrorism by developing the ASEAN Plan of Action to Prevent and Counter the Rise of Radicalisation and Violent Extremism, and the Bali Work Plan 2019–2025 as its implementing framework, which is in line with the GCTS.

Mr. Araba (Benin), (Vice-President), took the Chair.

My third point concerns strengthening multi-stakeholder engagement. Indonesia believes that collaboration should continue to be strengthened among the Government, civil society organizations, the media, religious leaders, academia and the private sector, while taking into account the voices of women, youth and victims of terrorist attacks. By promoting dialogue and information-sharing, we could optimize the different but complementary capacities of relevant stakeholders to enhance our collective ability to prevent and respond to acts of terrorism.

In closing, allow me to reaffirm Indonesia's commitment to strengthening efforts in countering terrorism based on a balanced implementation of the four pillars of the Strategy.

Mr. Hossain (Bangladesh): Bangladesh aligns itself with the statement delivered by the representative of Saudi Arabia on behalf of the Organization of Islamic Cooperation (OIC).

I would like to take this opportunity to express our appreciation to Ambassador Robert Rae of Canada and Ambassador Tarek Ladeb of Tunisia for their leadership in facilitating the eighth review of the United Nations Global Counter-Terrorism Strategy. Their experience and wisdom in tackling that complex task were truly commendable. Despite differing views on critical issues, the adoption by consensus of resolution 77/298, on the eighth review of the United Nations Global Counter-Terrorism Strategy, marks a significant milestone in our collective efforts to combat terrorism in all its forms and manifestations.

This year's review has come up with numerous vital courses of action to address terrorism and violent extremism on a global scale. We particularly acknowledge the emphasis placed on engaging community leaders and women-led civil society organizations to achieve the objectives of the Counter-Terrorism Strategy. Recognizing the importance of capacity-building in implementing the Strategy, it calls upon Member States and the United Nations system to provide support for enhancing the national capacities of Member States in countering terrorism and preventing extremist activities that fuel terrorism. Furthermore, the review encourages Member States, international and regional organizations to deepen their understanding and support initiatives aimed at addressing terrorism in the development and execution of global, regional and national counter-terrorism strategies.

Bangladesh, under the leadership of Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina, maintains a zero-tolerance policy on all forms of terrorism and violent extremism. We have always stood firm in not allowing any terrorist individual or entity to use our territory or resources. As stated by the Honourable Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina, terrorists are terrorists. They have no religion. As such, we strongly oppose any policy or action that allows the profiling of terrorists based on religion. We call upon Member States to invest further in addressing the root causes of terrorism and, to that end, to take measures

against economic, social and political exclusion, to stop the flow of arms and financing to terrorist groups, and to continue to strive for the peaceful settlement of all international disputes.

We express our gratitude to all delegations for their invaluable contributions during the negotiations of the eighth review. While the adoption of the review strategy today marks a positive step forward, our main challenge lies in its effective implementation. We thank the Secretary-General for his report, as contained in document A/77/718, which outlines the progress made by the United Nations system in implementing the Global Counter-Terrorism Strategy. We appreciate the continued support of the United Nations to Member States, through the United Nations Global Counter-Terrorism Coordination Compact, in developing and implementing responses under all four pillars of the Strategy.

In line with those efforts, we welcome the proposal put forth by the Secretary-General in his report entitled *Our Common Agenda* (A/75/982) to work on a new peace-focused agenda aimed at reducing strategic risks, including terrorism. We anticipate the same spirit of cooperation and leadership from the United Nations system for the implementation of the mandate derived from the review.

In conclusion, we reaffirm Bangladesh's unwavering commitment to combating terrorism and violent extremism in its all forms and manifestations.

Ms. Chan Valverde (Costa Rica) (*spoke in Spanish*): Costa Rica thanks the co-facilitators of the eighth revision of the United Nations Global Counter-Terrorism Strategy for their work during the negotiating process. It was not an easy job.

The review of the Strategy is a golden opportunity to improve the agreements we have reached, to take into account what we have learned since the previous review and to agree on more ambitious objectives. For that reason, during the review Costa Rica constructively presented multiple proposals for the text on transparency, accountability, evaluation, civil society participation and, in particular, the integration of a specific and contextualized gender analysis. However, we cannot hide our disappointment that the Strategy we adopted is not ambitious enough.

While we agree with the delegations that have said that the four pillars of the Strategy should be applied in a balanced manner in the fight against terrorism for

reasons of coherence, the values of promoting human rights and advancing gender equality should also find application in all prevention and response actions. They must therefore be present in a cross-cutting manner in the text. We regret most the lack of consensus on Costa Rica's proposal to include an analysis of human rights and gender in the study of conditions that are conducive to terrorism, keeping in mind that structural gender inequality disproportionately impacts women and girls, and exploring the link between masculinities and structural inequality.

Despite our efforts, pillar I of the eighth review of the Strategy still does not include any reference to gender or women. We are not there yet. I reiterate — not yet. This conversation is just beginning. Costa Rica will continue to present proposals, listen to arguments and build bridges that will one day allow us to overcome the gender blindness that fogs all international peace and security instruments and strategies. For Costa Rica, it is critical that we also analyse how gender relations influence men's and women's decisions to engage with violent extremist groups, how they influence the actions they take within those groups, and how they shape the stories that those groups tell about themselves. Many academic studies establish links between certain stereotypically masculine characteristics, such as aggressiveness, force and the perpetration of violent acts.

Another area where we have collectively failed is in strengthening oversight and accountability mechanisms. The General Assembly's request to the Secretary-General for a report that would include a study of the need for an internal advisory or monitoring and evaluation capacity on the effectiveness of the United Nations system's counter-terrorism activities was an encouraging first step. Although we have not been able to agree on a higher level of commitment, we hope that the call to the Secretary-General to report on the impact of activities in a results framework will allow us to keep moving in the right direction.

Let us always keep in mind that the words we agree to in the Strategy, as well as the activities we undertake to implement it, have an impact on communities and on the lives of people, on the victims and survivors whose testimonies we heard this week. For Costa Rica, it is vitally important to move forward in this and other United Nations processes, recognizing that consensus cannot be limited to the lowest common denominator, but must be a solid and ambitious commitment in search of effective and just solutions to the global challenges we face.

Mr. Aref (Islamic Republic of Iran): At the outset, please allow me to express my appreciation and sincere gratitude to the President and the co-facilitators for all the efforts made in this process.

We align ourselves with the statement delivered on behalf of the Organization of Islamic Cooperation (OIC) by the Permanent Representative of the Kingdom of Saudi Arabia.

Fighting terrorism requires strengthened will and determination and a genuine collective effort in the spirit of multilateralism. The United Nations, as the utmost expression of multilateralism, remains an unparalleled international setting for reinvigorating the wills of nations to counter terrorism. The review of the United Nations Global Counter-Terrorism Strategy (GCTS) has a particularly unique status in that regard, as it rekindles the call for concerted action and cooperation to fight that heinous criminal phenomenon.

As a nation that has long been a victim of terrorism and at the same time a champion in the fight against terrorism, we attach great importance to the reviews of the GCTS. The delegation of the Islamic Republic of Iran actively and in good faith engaged in that process with a view to continuing its contribution to multilateralism in fighting terrorism. Our delegation manifested utmost flexibility. We duly provided colleagues with the rationale and bases of our proposals and our very intention was to improve the ways and means of combating terrorism.

While many supported our proposals, certain delegations failed to even accept agreed language without enlightening us of the possible reasons for not considering those proposals. Regrettably, a similar approach was taken by the same delegations with respect to the proposals of the Organization of Islamic Cooperation. Among the very valuable and constructive proposals of the OIC, I would like to refer in particular to the language proposed regarding the importance of an effective response to terrorist attacks against Muslims that emanate from the incitement to terrorism through deliberate desecration of the Holy Quran and mosques. The very fact that this proposal was provided by more than 50 Member States is axiomatic and evinces that Muslims are unfortunately being victimized on a daily basis by racist and supremacist groups and that the hatred and Islamophobic narratives propagated by such groups and individuals create a fertile breeding ground for terrorists to target Muslims. However, the OIC

proposal addressing that issue was rejected without any concrete reason by some delegations in minority. It was very unfortunate that during those negotiations we, as an active member of the OIC, witnessed the incitement to terrorism and violence against Muslims being justified or ignored by a few.

We were willing to see the new review of the GCTS address in a more concrete manner the incitement to terrorism against Muslims, the main issues and the very new developments, as well as persistent and often deeply rooted challenges that hinder the efforts of Member States in fighting terrorism, including a lack of genuine cooperation on the part of the global Internet governance system in countering terrorism, double standards and the politicization of the fight against terrorism. But the intransigence of the few forestalled the many from reaching a balanced text and thus from efficiently advancing towards the common goal of a world free of terrorism. We will continue our engagement with other delegations to ensure that our joint future steps are focused on issues of common concerns, not those that would only be divisive, often repetitive or of no priority. That is of course without prejudice to the commendable efforts and tireless dedication of the co-facilitators in the process.

Nevertheless, despite our serious objections to the exclusion of many issues of priority for us, as well as of priority for the OIC, and in spite of the inclusion of certain new language, the benefit of which to counter-terrorism is not known, we once again demonstrated our commitment to a collective effort against terrorism by maintaining the consensus so that the United Nations as a whole can utilize this singular opportunity to reinforce the will, determination and resolve of the international community to a genuine fight against terrorism.

The Islamic Republic of Iran has manifested its unwavering determination and strong commitment in the fight against terrorism by effectively assisting affected States in combating and dismantling terrorist groups in the region. The bravest of our people, for the noblest of causes of humanity and divinity, have played a determining role and sacrificed their lives in fighting Daesh. In that respect, General Qasem Soleimani effectively led the counter-terrorism efforts in the region, resulting in a huge defeat of Daesh, and without which Daesh would have expanded its dominance of violence and terror beyond the region. I would like to seize this opportunity to commemorate the remarkable sacrifices of General Qasem Soleimani

and his companions in the fight against terrorism, who were martyred in a terrorist attack in Baghdad airport while on an official mission in Iraq.

We reaffirm that States shall desist and refrain from promulgating and applying unilateral coercive measures that are internationally wrongful acts that hinder international cooperation in countering terrorism. We condemn the systematic terrorist attacks against the Palestinian people, which are grave violations of fundamental human rights, as well as of the purposes and principles of the Charter of the United Nations. We also condemn in the strongest possible terms all acts of terrorism, including those targeting scientists and Government officials of Member States, as well as terrorist acts against and in sabotage of peaceful nuclear facilities.

In conclusion, reaffirming that measures taken in fighting terrorism should be in conformity with the fundamental principles of international law and the principles set forth within the Charter of the United Nations, we would like to reiterate our commitment to fighting terrorism and underline the pivotal role of the General Assembly, with universal membership, in addressing terrorism and in ensuring a balanced implementation of the GCTS. It is understood that the implementation of resolution 77/298 would be in accordance with national legislations, priorities and contexts.

Ms. Vittay (Hungary): Allow me to begin by applauding the consensus that has been reached on the United Nations Global Counter-Terrorism Strategy review resolution 77/298. We express our deepest appreciation to Canada and Tunisia for their tireless work during the consultations of the eighth review and for their strong efforts to find a compromise.

Hungary aligns itself with the statement of the European Union and wishes to add a few remarks in its national capacity.

The fight against terrorism is one of the key priorities of the Hungarian Government; therefore, we closely followed the review process. First, we commend the efforts to preserve the carefully crafted balance between the four pillars of the Strategy, and in that regard we are pleased to note that the resolution now includes references to the important Security Council resolution 2664 (2022) and to the role of women-led civil society organizations. However, we cannot refrain from mentioning some missing elements that would have been essential in making the Strategy futureproof and reflecting current challenges.

To illustrate our point, we inform the Assembly that just this week the Hungarian Counter-Terrorism Centre arrested a man who had planned to commit a terrorist attack in Hungary. The man is believed to have been inspired online by previous terrorist attacks. His goal was apparently to kill as many people as he could, and he posted videos on social media about his plans. With respect to that recent event, we wish to highlight that online radicalization and lone actors continue to present a persistent security threat, as also confirmed by the Secretary-General's report on the implementation of the GCTS issued this year (A/77/718). Unfortunately, the evolving danger of lone actors is not detailed in the text. Furthermore, we sadly note that the language on the potential misuse of new and emerging technologies for terrorist purposes has not been changed significantly since the previous review, despite not only the rapid development of those technologies, but also the human rights implications of countering their misuse.

Allow me to conclude by reaffirming that Hungary continues to uphold its commitment to the fight against terrorism and is enhancing its national efforts via international cooperation. That is exemplified by our recent joining of the Counter-Terrorism Travel Programme, operated by the Office of Counter-Terrorism (UNOCT). In that respect, we praise the intense work of UNOCT and its programme offices, and we note that this work requires sustainable and predictable financing. The implementation of the Strategy can be carried out only on a solid basis, and the mandate of the UNOCT can be delivered only if a stable financial background is provided.

Mr. Pérez Ayestarán (Bolivarian Republic of Venezuela) (*spoke in Spanish*): The Bolivarian Republic of Venezuela has the honour to take the floor on behalf of the Group of Friends in Defence of the Charter of the United Nations.

We take this opportunity to express our appreciation to the Secretary-General for submitting his report on the activities of the United Nations system in implementing the United Nations Global Counter-Terrorism Strategy (GCTS), as contained in document A/77/718, of which we have taken due note.

Terrorist acts endanger not only the territorial integrity and stability of States, but also national, regional and international peace and security. Not only do they generate terror and violate human rights, but they also seek to destabilize legitimately constituted

Governments or the prevailing constitutional order and political unity of States, thereby affecting the stability of entire nations and the very basis of societies. In addition, terrorist acts have adverse consequences, among others, on the economic and social development of nations, while resulting in both an incommensurable human toll and important economic losses, including as a result of the destruction of States' vital public and private infrastructure.

We therefore express our categorical rejection of all acts of terrorism, regardless of their motivation, wherever, whenever and by whomsoever committed. All acts, methods and practices of terrorism are criminal and unjustifiable and represent clear violations of both the purposes and principles of the Charter of the United Nations and the norms of international law. Similarly, the provision of any sort of support, active or passive, to terrorist organizations or persons for the purpose of inciting, planning, financing, perpetrating or participating in the carrying out of terrorist acts is also contrary to the values, tenets and spirit of the founding Charter of our Organization.

That being said, we should stress, on the one hand, that terrorism shall in no way be equated with the legitimate struggle of peoples under colonial or alien domination and foreign occupation for self-determination and national liberation, and, on the other, that terrorism shall not be associated with any religion, nationality, civilization or ethnic group. Similarly, we reject the political manipulation of the fight against terrorism, including through the issuance of arbitrary and unilateral lists accusing States of allegedly supporting terrorism — a practice that, it goes without saying, is totally inconsistent with international law.

We also stress that the promotion or facilitation of terrorism, as well as the use of digital platforms to incite and finance terrorist acts for the purpose of advancing regime-change policies or agendas seeking neocolonial domination is clearly inadmissible. We cannot overemphasize that efforts to prevent and combat international terrorism should not be used, in any circumstance, as a pretext to interfere in the internal affairs of States or to resort to the use or threat of use of force against the territorial integrity or political independence of any State, which clearly contradicts both the very spirit and letter of the Charter of the United Nations.

The adoption by consensus of resolution 77/298, through which the General Assembly has unanimously renewed yet again the United Nations Global Counter-Terrorism Strategy, is a clear demonstration of the unwavering commitment of the international community to efforts to both prevent and combat terrorism in all its forms and manifestations. We reaffirm, in that context, the leading role and primary responsibility of States and their respective national institutions, with the assistance of the United Nations, in the framework of the Global Strategy and upon request, in efforts at the national, regional and international levels to both prevent and counter this despicable scourge.

We recognize that, indeed, much has been achieved since the adoption of the Global Strategy in 2006. Nevertheless, there is still a long road ahead in achieving our common goal of a world free of terrorism, which requires, among other things, a balanced implementation of the Global Strategy and full compliance with the relevant international obligations. This is a fight that brooks no dichotomies or double standards. We must clearly state that there cannot be good and bad terrorists. In that context, and mindful of the fact that terrorism will not be defeated by military force, law enforcement measures and intelligence operations alone, we emphasize the importance of comprehensively addressing the root causes of terrorism, in line with the provisions of pillar I of the Global Strategy, with a view to effectively overcoming conditions that may provide breeding grounds for the promotion of criminal agendas based on hatred, defamation, intolerance, sectarianism, racism, extremism, including supremacism and neo-Nazism, and that seek to exploit the divisions and challenges facing each nation for the sole purpose of inflaming tensions and fostering the commission of terrorist acts. We refer, *inter alia*, to poverty, social and economic inequalities, political and ethnic intolerance and/or conflicts, as well as colonial or alien domination and foreign occupation, and systematic violations of the sovereignty and territorial integrity of peoples and nations, all of which are part of the so-called drivers of terrorism. We are therefore of the view that if we truly want to eliminate the scourge of terrorism in both the short and the long terms, we must decisively address those all those factors.

The Group of Friends expresses its resolve to take speedy and effective measures rooted in international legality and the tenets of the founding Charter of our Organization to eliminate international terrorism once and for all. In that connection, we consider of utmost

importance the further strengthening and broadening of international cooperation and the provision of technical assistance, upon request, and based on the needs and priorities identified by requesting States, so that we can effectively advance towards that end. Consequently, we also take this opportunity to reiterate our call for the removal of unilateral coercive measures, which hinder such cooperation and thereby deliberately keep us from achieving the world free of terrorism to which we aspire. Moreover, we also insist on the need to resume, as soon as possible, negotiations on a comprehensive convention on international terrorism, covering all aspects of that phenomenon, as we are confident that such a treaty would complement the set of existing legal instruments in this field.

In conclusion, while expressing our full solidarity with those countries that have most recently suffered from acts of terrorism, we renew our determination to preserve, promote and defend the prevalence and validity of the Charter of the United Nations. We call on all responsible members of the international community to set aside their differences and, instead, to engage with each other and work together, in a decisive, inclusive and coordinated manner, in order to eliminate that reprehensible scourge, including through the full, effective and balanced implementation of the United Nations Global Counter-Terrorism Strategy.

Mr. Papakostas (Greece): At the outset, Greece would like to congratulate the co-facilitators, the Permanent Representatives of Canada and Tunisia, as well as their teams for the work carried out in preparing the eighth review of the United Nations Global Counter-terrorism Strategy (GCTS).

Greece also aligns itself with the statement delivered by the observer of the European Union and wishes to make the following remarks in its national capacity.

Allow me to start by adding our voice to the expressions of condolences to the people and the Government of Uganda in relation to the recent attacks that took place on its territory on 17 June, just five days ago.

In today's turbulent world, the complex global security environment has become increasingly volatile and fragmented. The re-emergence of long-term security dilemmas and the strategic competition between nations entangled with non-conventional and transnational threats, such as terrorism, challenge the ability of the multilateral system to mitigate them.

The fight against the scourge of terrorism, which constitutes one of the greatest threats to the achievements obtained in the field of justice, security and freedom, continues to be a priority for the United Nations and the Member States. As international cooperation is an essential component in dealing with that common threat, the Strategy constitutes an indispensable instrument that provides a shared collaboration scheme. The eighth review of the Strategy is a tool that underscores the central role of the United Nations in global counter-terrorism, demonstrates our continuous commitment and provides the necessary adaptation to the transformation of terrorism. Greece actively participates in our common effort and in that respect wishes to highlight specifically the following issues.

First, at a time when terrorist actions are constantly transformed and shifted in different parts of the world, the GCTS incorporates a holistic approach to countering terrorism. Combating terrorism requires a wide anti-terrorist agenda focusing on prevention and addressing, in particular, the underlying drivers of radicalization and violent extremism by engaging with Governments and local religious leaders.

Secondly, during the current review of the Strategy, the relevant paragraphs of the General Assembly resolution corresponding to illicit trafficking and trade of cultural property from which terrorists may benefit or which may be targeted by terrorist attacks were not significantly modified. Yet, we would like to underline the importance of strengthening in practical terms and concrete policies the efforts to combat illicit trafficking and trade in cultural property so that terrorists may not benefit from it. According to UNESCO, such looting contributes substantially to the financing of terrorist groups. We also need to ensure the return of exported or imported, illicitly excavated or stolen cultural property to the countries of origin. Greece consistently supports the inclusion of trafficking of archaeological objects obtained through looting or illegal excavations into the actions to counter the financing of the terrorism agenda.

Thirdly, it is our view that civil society actors and, as part of a whole-of-society approach, woman-led civil society organizations in particular, should be further encouraged and enabled to contribute to the goals of the Strategy within an environment that respects, protects and promotes human rights, in accordance with international human rights law.

Lastly, we would like to underline the importance of Security Council resolution 2664 (2022) so that, within its terms and in accordance with obligations of States under international law, counter-terrorism legislation and measures do not impede humanitarian and medical activities or engagement with all relevant actors in a manner consistent with international humanitarian law.

Greece welcomes the adoption of the resolution 77/298, containing the eighth review of the GCTS, which is strengthening and enhancing efforts to prevent and counter terrorism. It is our firm belief that, through unity and solidarity, we will consolidate progress. We stand ready to contribute and cooperate in the implementation of all pillars of the Strategy.

Mr. Ugarelli (Peru) (*spoke in Spanish*): At the outset, Peru wishes to thank the Permanent Representatives of Canada and Tunisia, as well as their respective teams, for the professionalism and dedication with which they led the arduous and delicate United Nations Global Counter-Terrorism Strategy review process. We welcome the fact that, once again, the Strategy was adopted by consensus (resolution 77/298), as has traditionally been the case since 2006, and along those lines we reaffirm its relevance and our shared responsibility to update it in the face of new challenges and realities. We consider it fundamental to reaffirm that the acts, methods and practices of terrorism in all their forms and manifestations are activities that aim to deny human rights and democracy, for which reason the international community is committed to preventing and combating terrorism in a decisive, unified, coordinated, inclusive and transparent manner that guarantees respect for fundamental rights.

We reiterate the importance of strengthening synergies among the United Nations Office of Counter-Terrorism, the Counter-Terrorism Committee and the Counter-Terrorism Committee Executive Directorate, within the framework of their respective mandates, with a view to providing comprehensive support to States, basing technical assistance on the appropriate needs assessment. That will contribute to the implementation of the Strategy in a coordinated, comprehensive and balanced manner among all its pillars, and in accordance with the obligations incumbent on Member States under international law, human rights, refugee law and international humanitarian law.

It is essential to support the victims of terrorism to ensure that they are treated with dignity and respect. Their right of access to justice and reparation mechanisms

must be guaranteed. Strengthening the capacity of States to assist victims is critical to honouring and supporting the victims and survivors of terrorism, and to protecting the full enjoyment of their human rights and fundamental freedoms. Within that framework, care for victims of terrorism has been one of the priority objectives for the Government of Peru, as recognized in the National Multisectoral Policy to Fight Terrorism 2019-2023.

We deem it necessary and important to mention the threat posed by violent extremism that can lead to terrorism. On the one hand, we must address inequalities and other structural causes, in line with national development policies and the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development, in particular Sustainable Development Goals 1 and 16. On the other hand, we must avoid the radicalization of individuals and strengthen the social fabric, together with actors from civil society, academia and the private sector. This is a fight that takes place in the realm of ideas, where we must overcome the rhetoric of violence and resentment with a message of peace and reconciliation.

In the fight against the financing of terrorism, the work of the financial intelligence units and customs are decisive. The very nature of the phenomenon we are facing requires us to improve the mechanisms for cooperation and exchange of information among those entities, nationally and internationally. In that regard, we believe that the Financial Action Task Force and its regional affiliates play an important role in promoting and assisting States in strengthening their financial systems. By attacking the mechanisms and their sources of financing, we will limit the ability of terrorist groups to attack.

In that regard, we must highlight the importance of addressing the link between terrorism and transnational organized crime, the mutually beneficial dynamics between which we can list. In that vein, we highlight the link that transnational organized crime can have with terrorism. It is essential to improve cooperation at the national, subregional, regional and international levels in order to strengthen the capacity of States to respond to the challenge. In the same way, it is necessary to maintain a commitment and concerted action to prevent and dismantle illicit financial flows destined for terrorist purposes.

We welcome the incorporation of elements that reinforce the Strategy with a focus on human rights and gender, as well as the recognition of the threat from

the use of new and emerging technologies. We wish to recall once again the importance of redoubling our efforts to finalize the process of drafting a general convention on international terrorism.

I wish to conclude by expressing Peru's firm commitment and support in the fight against the threats posed by this scourge.

Mr. Peñaranda (Philippines): The Philippines welcomes the adoption by consensus of resolution 77/298, on the eighth review of the United Nations Global Counter-Terrorism Strategy (GCTS). We thank the co-facilitators, Canada and Tunisia, as well as their teams, for their leadership. We thank the Secretary-General for his reports (A/77/266 and A/77/718), which have informed that process.

A consensual and truly global counter-terrorism strategy, reflecting balance among the diverse interests of the Member States, as well as balance among the four pillars of the Strategy, is critical for States confronted with terrorism. The world has changed since 2021, when we last adopted the United Nations Global Counter-Terrorism Strategy (GCTS) (resolution 75/291). The coronavirus disease pandemic altered the global security landscape. With ensuing border restrictions, terrorists have shifted operations in cyberspace, where they spew narratives for a captive online audience and where they continue to prowl until now.

Just six years ago, a terrorist organization inspired by Daesh laid siege to Marawi, in southern Philippines. A network analysis later established that the Group had ties to international terrorist groups that facilitated the flow of funds, foreign terrorist fighters and material support. The Philippines acted swiftly by adopting a national strategy based on the GCTS; partnering with communities; countering terrorist financing; enhancing border control, including through joint maritime border patrols; ramping up law enforcement; optimizing international cooperation; and revamping our counter-terrorism legislation. We also work closely with partners on the United Nations Countering Terrorist Travel Programme in both the air and the maritime domains.

The outlook has changed, and significant progress has been made, as our officials have highlighted in briefings before the Security Council Counter-Terrorism Committee. While Member States have the primary responsibility to counter terrorism, the Marawi incident, with its transnational elements, demonstrates the need for a global strategy. To stay relevant, the GCTS must

remain a living document, evolving with the times and the shifting paradigms of terrorism but realistic and responsive to the needs of Member States. The Philippines, therefore, while welcoming updates in the eighth iteration of the GCTS and the retention of key principles, notes that the review period may be short. We look forward to substantive updates three years from now, when the GCTS marks its twentieth year.

We affirm the importance of human rights and international humanitarian law so that fighting terrorists is done without the careless disregard of human rights that recruits their replacements. The 2021 United Nations Joint Programme on Human Rights in the Philippines is a tool for fostering systematic and coherent engagement among United Nations entities, Member States, international partners and civil society. As counter-terrorism cuts across different United Nations entities — among them, the Office of Counter-Terrorism (UNOCT), the United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime, the Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Human Rights, and the United Nations country team unit/resident coordinator — greater synergy and coherence are needed. The Joint Programme provides a good model for harnessing multilateralism towards concrete, practical and relevant cooperation at the country level. One of the six areas of technical cooperation under the Joint Programme is on the human rights-based approach to counter-terrorism, in partnership with UNOCT. We work closely with UNOCT, including on advancing the protection of the rights of victims of terrorism, in line with our holistic approach, which integrates the need to address socioeconomic drivers and to strengthen related rehabilitation and reintegration programmes.

We welcome capacity-building programmes in partnership with the United Nations entities and other States, while stressing that they must be constructive, anchored in the needs of the countries concerned and duly informed by the development and security context on the ground. They must duly take national priorities into account and should be pursued in coordination with duty-bearers. Given the transnational nature of extremism and terrorism, the implementation of national action plans can benefit from forging stronger cooperation among national, regional and multilateral organizations and mechanisms.

We remain committed to the idea that counter-terrorism efforts should be based on respect for the sovereignty, territorial integrity, independence and unity of all States, in accordance with the Charter of the United Nations.

Under the eighth iteration of the GCTS, we look forward to working with UNOCT, the Counter-Terrorism Committee Executive Directorate, United Nations entities with the relevant mandates and other partners for the integrated and balanced implementation of the Strategy across the United Nations system and to pursuing counter-terrorism efforts consistent with respect for national ownership and national priorities.

Mr. Rakhmetullin (Kazakhstan): Nothing can ever justify an act of terrorism. No religious pretext can ever excuse violent methods. At the same time, we will never be able to defeat terrorism in the long term unless we address the conditions that are conducive to its spread.

Unfortunately, the issue of combating terrorism remains urgent. In that context, Kazakhstan believes that the United Nations Global Counter-Terrorism Strategy remains a unique instrument to enhance national, regional and international efforts to counter terrorism. The Strategy not only sends a clear message that terrorism is unacceptable in all its forms and manifestations, but it also resolves to take practical steps, individually and collectively, to prevent and combat terrorism. Those practical steps include a wide array of measures ranging from strengthening State capacity to counter terrorist threats to better coordinating United Nations system activities.

Kazakhstan continues to contribute to international efforts to combat terrorism. Our country has ratified all 19 United Nations universal counter-terrorism conventions and protocols and strictly implements all relevant resolutions of the Security Council. Kazakhstan supports the implementation of the Joint Action Plan approved in March 2022 for the implementation of the United Nations Global Counter-Terrorism Strategy in

Central Asia. Twenty-five organizations, including the Islamic State in Iraq and the Sham and Al-Qaida, have been recognized by the judicial authorities of Kazakhstan as extremist and terrorist. We take practical steps to counter money laundering and the financing of terrorism.

To counter the propaganda of extremism and terrorism on the Internet, a cybercontrol information system was put into practical operation in Kazakhstan in 2019. We pay special attention to the rehabilitation of Kazakhstan citizens returned from Syria and Iraq as a result of the Zhusan and Rusafa humanitarian operations, particularly women and children. More than 620 citizens were brought back to Kazakhstan from conflict zones. The overwhelming majority of them returned to normal life and were reintegrated into society. In our region, we implement, alongside the United Nations Regional Centre for Preventive Diplomacy for Central Asia, the Strengthening Resilience Against Violent Extremism in Asia programme, which is aimed at fostering resilience in countering violent extremism. We also continue to financially support the implementation of those measures. Last year, Kazakhstan allocated \$50,000 to the project activities of the United Nations Office of Counter-Terrorism. The same amount was allocated this year.

In conclusion, I reiterate our strong support for bilateral and multilateral actions aimed at achieving a world free from terrorism.

The Acting President (spoke in French): We have heard the last speaker on this item for this meeting. We will hear the remaining speakers this afternoon at 3 p.m.

The meeting rose at 1 p.m.